

## Ch11: Online Communities, Virtual Reality, And Artificial Intelligence

### P2: Virtual Worlds & RPGs



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### Defining "Virtual" in Virtual Environments

- 1) contrasted with "real," as in cases where virtual objects are differentiated from "real objects";
- 2) contrasted with "actual" – e.g., where a person claims that she is "virtually finished" her project;
- 3) used to express a feeling that one has "as if" he or she were physically present – i.e., the feeling of presence that one can have in a telephone conversation or an online messaging exchange.

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### VEs and Virtual Worlds

- Not only do VEs subsume virtual (or online) communities, they also subsume (what some authors call) *virtual worlds*.
- What are virtual worlds, and how are they similar to and different from VEs.
- Søraker and Brey describe virtual worlds as a type of VE in which users typically:
  - a) are "represented by avatars";
  - b) have the "illusion of perceiving a three dimensional world consisting of virtual objects."

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## Module Objectives

Upon completion of this lesson the students should be able to:

- Describe and discuss concerns about social and ethical behaviors arising from interactions in **massively multiplayer online role-playing games (MMORPGs)**
- Discuss the implications of role-playing in online environments for our understanding of **personal identity**

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### Virtual Environments (Continued)

- As already noted, VEs exist in *virtual space*.
- What is meant by "virtual space"?
- Virtual space can be viewed as a range of **computer-generated environments that could not exist without computers and cybertechnology.**
- These environments, in turn, include online (or virtual) communities, as well as (three-dimensional) virtual reality (VR) applications.

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### Defining Virtual Reality and VR Applications

- What, exactly, is meant by the expressions "virtual reality" and "VR application"?
- Brey (1999) defines virtual reality (VR), as well as a VR application, as ***"a three-dimensional interactive computer-generated environment that incorporates a first-person perspective."*** [Italics Added]

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## Virtual Reality vs. *Augmented Reality*

- So, VR applications typically provide the user with a “simulated world,” thereby replacing the real world.
- AR technology, on the contrary, enhances (or *augments*) a user’s view of the real world.

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## Ethical Aspects of VR Applications

- Brey also notes that VR users are not spectators, but rather are more like actors, i.e., as are the board game players who also act out roles in certain board games.
- But Brey also points out that VR applications, unlike board games, simulate the world in a way that gives it a much greater appearance of reality.
- In VR applications, the player has a first-person perspective of what it is like to perform certain acts and roles, including some that are criminal or immoral, or both.
- We next examine some ethical aspects of one type of VR application: online video games.

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## Ethical Aspects of Online Video Games

- We should note that some analysts differentiate single-player video games from multi-player online games, which are commonly referred to as MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Games).
- MMORPGs include games such as *Second Life* and *World of Warcraft*.
- *Second Life* (designed by Linden Lab), which includes members called “Residents,” (has 1million regular users as of 2014, and 13 million registered accounts as of 2008).
- *World of Warcraft (WOW)*, one of the most popular MMORPGs, has 7 million subscribers as of Aug. 2014.

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## Violent and Sexually-Offensive Acts in MMORPGs

- Some critics claim that *Second Life* facilitates child pornography because virtual characters who are adults in real life can have sex with virtual characters who are children in that MMORPG (Singer, 2007).
- Wonderly (2008) suggests that some forms of violence permitted in online games be “more morally problematic” than pornography and other kinds of sexually offensive behavior in virtual environments.

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## Assessing “Harm” Resulting from Acts in VEs and VR Applications

- Is it wrong to perform acts in VEs and VR applications that would be considered immoral in “real life”?
- Can these acts cause *real harm*?
- We might think that since no one can be physically harmed in a VE, any harm caused in the virtual realm is not “real harm” but only *virtual harm*.

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## Arguments for Evaluating Harm in Virtual Environments/VR Applications

- Brey describes two kinds of arguments that can help us to evaluate harm in virtual environments:
  1. *The argument from moral development*, which reasons that the way we treat virtual characters can affect the way we treat real-life people.
  2. *The argument from psychological harm*, which reasons that the way we interact with virtual characters can cause psychological harm to people in real-life situations who have suffered harm (e.g., as in the case of Lambda-Moo and real-life rape victims).

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## Virtual Economies and "Gold Farming"

- Kimppa and Bisset (2008) define gold farming as "playing an online computer game for the purpose of gaining items of value within the internal economy of the game and selling these to other players for real money."
- These "virtual" items can include "desirable items" as well as in-game money (where the rules defining the game's internal economy permit this).
- The items can also include "highly developed" game characters.

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## Virtual Economies and "Gold Farming" (Continued)

- In some cases, gold-farming practices have become advantageous to the "gold farmers" themselves, who were able to earn more money obtaining and selling virtual gold than they could than in traditional agricultural work.
- But gold-farming practices have also led to reported cases of Chinese sweatshops, where laborers can work "day and night in conditions of practical slavery" to acquire the virtual gold and virtual resources (Brey 2013).

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